

## Campaign Critique

Title: TikTok Barbiecore Challenge in Barbie 2023 Global PR Campaign

Critique

## **1. Background Introduction**

The Barbie brand, launched in 1959 by Mattel, has long been iconic—praised for imagination but criticized for unrealistic beauty ideals (Morrison, 2023). In 2023, Greta Gerwig's Barbie film and its PR campaign aimed to revive the brand and reposition Barbie as a progressive cultural icon.

## **2. Situation Analysis**

Barbie faced criticism for reinforcing stereotypes and unrealistic beauty standards. Although recent efforts promoted diversity and inclusivity, cultural relevance and trust remained low, especially among socially conscious youth. Meanwhile, social media fueled nostalgic aesthetics and identity-driven branding, with feminism and self-expression becoming key to pop culture and consumer values.

## **3. Campaign Goal**

Therefore, the campaign aimed to reposition Barbie as a progressive and self-aware figure, using humor and vivid visuals to connect with inter-generational audiences. This PR campaign isn't just about promoting the Barbie movie—it's only the beginning. What they're really aiming to do is use this opportunity to revive Barbie culture, thus enhancing the overall value of the IP brand.

## **4. Key Objectives**

Firstly, increase movie viewership: this is the most direct and measurable PR objective, with effectiveness assessable through audience data and feedback.

Secondly, create a cultural phenomenon beyond the film: the PR strategy transformed the promotion into a global event, leveraging media and social platforms to reestablish Barbie as a cultural icon. Lastly, reignite global interest in the Barbie brand: as Hawkins (2023) noted, the campaign aimed to make Barbie omnipresent, particularly re-engaging adult audiences, especially those in their twenties and beyond.

5. Target Public and why them

(Target Public Classification for the TikTok Barbiecore Challenge, Based on Situational Theory of Publics. Based on this, I have selected Primary and Secondary Target Public and tell why them.)

| Target Public Classification for the TikTok Barbiecore Challenge, Based on Situational Theory of Publics |                                                                          |                                                                                                             |         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| Category                                                                                                 | Description                                                              | TikTok User Characteristics                                                                                 | Example |
| Non-public                                                                                               | No interest in Barbie or the movie                                       | Does not follow popular culture, does not use TikTok or social media                                        |         |
| Potential public                                                                                         | Exposed to Barbiecore but has not formed an interest or opinion          | Occasionally comes across related videos but does not like or comment                                       |         |
| Aware public                                                                                             | Knows about the challenge, has initial emotional resonance               | Has seen related content, finds it interesting, expresses support but has not participated in the challenge |         |
| Active public                                                                                            | Actively participates in challenges, creates content, sparks discussions | Dresses in Barbie-style clothes, posts videos with the hashtag #Barbiecore, tags friends to join in         |         |

The primary target audience: Millennial and Gen Z Women (Ages 20–35)

Racker (2023) thought this demographic likely grew up with Barbie and now engages deeply with social media and pop culture. The campaign aimed to tap into their nostalgia while aligning with contemporary values of empowerment and inclusivity.

(Grunig, Grunig & Dozier, 2002) The secondary target audience: Fashion and Beauty Enthusiasts. Barbie has long been a fashion icon. Targeting this group helped reinforce Barbie's status in the fashion world and attract consumers interested in style and trends.

## **6. PR Activities Timeline**

Phase 1: Brand Collaborations & Visual Identity (Spring 2023)

Over 100 partnerships with brands like Crocs, Aldo, Gap, and Xbox expanded Barbie's cultural presence.

Phase 2: Immersive Marketing & Experience Economy (June 2023)

The Malibu Dreamhouse was listed on Airbnb, allowing fans to live the "Barbie life" in a real-world setting. (The related picture can be found in Appendix A)

Phase 3: Peak Awareness & Cultural Engagement (July 2023 onwards)

The TikTok Barbiecore Challenge went viral; subsequent conferences explored Barbie's impact on feminism, body politics and pop culture.

## **7. Specific Activity**

The TikTok Barbiecore Challenge is a social media trend where users channel the iconic Barbie aesthetic by showcasing vibrant pink fashion, glamorous makeup, and ultra-feminine vibes. Influenced by the 2023 Barbie movie, this trend celebrates nostalgia, self-expression, and empowerment. Participants post videos styled in Barbiecore looks. (The related picture can be found in Appendix B).

## **8. Strategy and Tactics**

Agenda-Setting Theory (McCombs & Shaw, 1972): Through the Barbiecore Challenge, the brand strategically utilized social media to elevate themes such as femininity, self-expression and body positivity. By setting these topics at the forefront of online trends, Barbie effectively influenced what global audiences considered socially and culturally relevant. This theory explains the phenomenon to a large extent but has limitations: it promotes a narrow ideal of femininity—thin, white, young, and beautiful—while sidelining diverse bodies, genders, and races.

Two-Step Flow Theory (Lazarsfeld & Katz, 1955): This theory highlights how opinion leaders mediate media influence. In the Barbiecore Challenge, TikTok influencers acted as cultural intermediaries—interpreting Barbie’s messaging and reshaping it into relatable, engaging content. This personalized approach amplified the trend and deepened emotional engagement among followers, so it works well in this activities.

Integrated Marketing Communication (Schultz, 1991): Barbie’s campaign exemplified Integrated Marketing Communication by delivering a unified message across multiple channels. From social media to in-store collaborations with brands like Zara, the message of "Barbiecore" was consistently communicated. The synergy between digital content, physical products, and experiential marketing ensured broad visibility and a cohesive brand experience.

User-Generated Content: It emphasizes active audience involvement in shaping brand narratives. The TikTok Barbiecore Challenge transformed consumers into co-creators, allowing them to reinterpret the Barbie brand through their own cultural and stylistic lenses. This co-creation deepened emotional bonds and repositioned Barbie as a participatory brand attuned to its audience's evolving values.

Public Engagement Theory (Bucchi & Trench, 2008): It argues that brands must consider the interests of all relevant parties. Barbie's engagement extended beyond consumers to include influencers, gender rights advocates and cultural commentators. This inclusive approach allowed the brand to reflect a multiplicity of values and perspectives, enhancing its credibility and societal relevance. But, this approach boosts brand consumerism, blending user creativity with commercial goals while obscuring the brand's social and cultural values, and also overemphasizes consumerism. Additionally, good communication ideas and interesting perspectives must respect ethics and morality; otherwise, they may offend certain groups. PR teams, in particular, need strong media sensitivity and social responsibility to avoid issues like the "Barbenheimer" phenomenon, which offended some Japanese people, as will be discussed later.

Stakeholder Theory (Freeman, 1984): Academic dialogues on Barbie involve different kind of stakeholders—scholars, activists, the public, and the brand—shaping discussions on feminism, body politics, and pop culture. These dialogues influence Barbie's perception and brand evolution, making stakeholder involvement key to cultural and brand dynamics. However, there are also some issues, such as the brand's

market expansion goals potentially overlooking social responsibilities, such as cultural diversity and gender equality.

**Brand Community:** It enhance emotional resonance and identity. Barbiecore is more than a fashion challenge — it's a cultural expression that embraces themes like female empowerment, playful freedom, and gender identity. Participants find a sense of “I am Barbie,” strengthening emotional ties and brand identification. Totally, the theory works well in this activity.

**Transmedia Storytelling:** The TikTok Barbiecore Challenge exemplifies transmedia storytelling by extending the Barbie narrative across platforms. Originating from the 2023 film, it invites user-generated content, fashion, and aesthetics to co-create a vibrant, empowering world. Each medium adds unique layers, fostering community, identity expression, and immersive cultural participation.

## **9. Impact and Outcomes**

Firstly, the Barbie film grossed over \$1.5 billion worldwide, becoming the highest-grossing movie of 2023, with Mattel's Barbie product sales reaching \$1.7 billion, the highest since 2013 (Hawthorne Strategy, 2023).

Secondly, Barbiecore's popularity boosted related product sales, with pink mini skirts up by 970% and pink swimwear by 682%, while the #Barbiecore hashtag surpassed 500 million views on TikTok (Siddiqui, 2022).

Next, Mattel saw a 16% increase in Barbie doll sales in Q3 2023, linked to the film's popularity, but overall annual revenue remained close to \$5.44 billion (Mccoll, 2023).

Then, according to Schulz (2023): In the lead up to the Barbie release, fashion has doubled down on pink. From Barbie-branded fast fashion collabs to pink-heavy luxury collections.

Finally, the Circuit of Culture Model shows Barbiecore's spread on TikTok, using pink, glitter, and retro fashion to reflect the Representation aspect, reinforcing Barbie's cultural image with irony and self-parody.

## **10. Evaluation**

Firstly, media monitoring: Barbie's name alone did not account for the brand's over 250,000 media mentions in 2023 (Propel 2023) Secondly, engagement metrics: from July to September 2023, the number of likes on social media posts related to Barbie showed a significant increase for three consecutive months (This information can be found in Appendix B). Next, Stakeholder Feedback: Academics and Activists— While some scholars acknowledge Barbie's progress in gender expression, others argue that its feminist message remains superficial, bordering on "pink-washing." Finally, Impact Reporting: Mattel's Response— According to RepTrak, the Barbie movie improved Mattel's brand reputation, with a one-point increase in brand score from June to July 2023, along with gains in ESG and corporate citizenship metrics.

## **11. Effectiveness in Achieving Objectives**

Gober (2024) said that “Barbie” is a prime example of a movie whose success was driven by its ability to go viral. The sensation that “Barbie” became was thanks to a



combination of the audience's appreciation for its IP, the "girl power" effect, and the marketing and PR teams' extraordinary understanding of the audience.

## **12. Current Issues**

The "Barbenheimer" phenomenon saw Warner Bros. US engaging with fan content combining Barbie and Oppenheimer, including nuclear imagery, which angered Japan due to its history with Hiroshima and Nagasaki. Warner Bros. Japan expressed regret, and the US headquarters later apologized for lacking cultural sensitivity.

### **Criticism of Over-commercialization and Consumerism**

The 2023 Barbie campaign gained global attention but was criticized for excessive commercialism and consumerism. Critics said it prioritized brand deals over social responsibility and cultural diversity.

## **13. Recommendations in improving the campaign**

To reduce offense and emphasize the respect for cultural history and have taken corrective actions to prevent similar incidents in the future. Also, sincerely apologize to the people of Japan who were hurt by this.

Shift toward value-driven PR by aligning with nonprofits or purpose-led brands that promote gender equality, education or sustainability. Actively listen to audience feedback via real-time engagement and adapt strategies based on sentiment analysis.

## **14. The reason why recommendations can deliver a better result**

According to Image Repair Theory (Benoit, 1995) This approach is more than a surface-level apology—it is a theoretically grounded response that uses the principles of Image Repair Theory to actively rebuild trust, reduce offense, and restore the organization's reputation through acknowledgment, respect, corrective commitment, and emotional sincerity.

The Two-Way Symmetrical Model (Grunig, 2001) emphasizes mutual understanding and dialogue between organizations and publics, rather than one-way persuasion. It encourages organizations to co-create social values with the public, making it ideal for brand communication strategies focused on gender equality, education, and sustainability, aligning with Corporate Social Responsibility.

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## Appendix

Appendix A: Barbie's Malibu DreamHouse is being made available to rent via a partnership with Airbnb. Photograph: Airbnb/Reuters



Appendix B: Pictures about TikTok Barbiecore Challenge in Barbie 2023 Global PR Campaign



Appendix C: Social Media Engagement for Barbie 2023 Global PR Campaign

Social Media Engagement for Barbie 2023 Global PR Campaign

